

SPRAWLING PRESENCE
The RIL refinery at Jamnagar, Gujarat

AFP

economics, worked closely on RIL's 4G telecom venture before becoming a director at the group firms. Both Akash and Isha were key negotiators in mega deals that Jio Platforms, RIL's digital arm, struck with the likes of Google, Facebook and Intel to turn the group into a futuristic enterprise. They were also involved in all big acquisitions by Jio Platforms, including Den Networks, Hathway Cable and Datacom.

At Reliance Jio, Akash is involved in the development of products and digital services applications. He also handles sports businesses and runs the Indian Premier League team Mumbai Indians. Isha looks into consumer experience, branding and marketing, and also assists mother Nita Ambani at Reliance Foundation.

Anant is a graduate from Brown University and sits on the board of Reliance New Energy Solar Limited. He is slated to take a leadership role in the energy business and has been involved with the Jamnagar refinery complex. While the revenues of RIL's oil to chemicals business declined 29 per cent in 2020-21 to Rs 3.2 lakh crore due to the pandemic-induced price correction, digital services posted Rs 90,287 crore in revenues, up from Rs 69,605 crore in 2019-20.

RIL is also building a leadership base outside the Ambani family. The RIL board, chaired by Mukesh Ambani, has four executive directors—Nikhil R. Meswani, Hital R. Meswani, P.M.S Prasad and Pawan Kumar Kapil. The nine non-executive/ independent directors are Nita Ambani, Arundhati Bhattacharya, K.V. Chowdary, Yasir O. Al-Rumayyan, Dipak C. Jain, R.A. Mashelkar, Adil Zainulbhai, R.S. Gujral and Shumeet Banerji.

THE NEXT-GENERATION AMBANIS HAVE BEEN GROOMED FOR ALL THE NEW-AGE BUSINESSES OF THE GROUP: RETAIL, DIGITAL, TELECOM AND CLEAN ENERGY. RIL IS ALSO BUILDING A LEADERSHIP BASE OUTSIDE THE FAMILY

Other senior professionals heading various departments or businesses present a mix of experience and young blood. There are industry veterans, in the 50-65 age group, such as Alok Agarwal, the group's chief financial officer; Subramaniam V., MD of Reliance Retail; Sanjay Mashruwala and Mathew Oommen, both presidents at Reliance Jio; and Pankaj Pawar, business head of Jio. The oil to chemicals business has P.K. Kapil as executive director, Sanjiv Singh as group president and Srinivas Tuttagunta as director.

These businesses further have a string of leaders in the 35-50 age bracket being groomed for bigger roles, such as Anshuman Thakur, head of strategy, Reliance Jio; Kaushal Nevrekar, chief business officer, Reliance Digital; Saurabh Sancheti, CFO at Jio Platforms; Raj Mulick, chief accounts officer of RIL; Ashwin Khasgiwala, CFO, Reliance Retail; Kiran Thomas, president, Jio; Ashish Lodha and Aayush Bhatnagar, senior vice-presidents at Jio Platforms; R. Srinivasan, president-revenue and commercial operations, Jio; Soumya Dutta, head of treasury; and Sanjay Roy, head of deepwater oil and gasfields assets.

ISB's Ramachandran says even if the Ambani scions are not fully ready, they can bank on this experienced team. RIL has put in place various grooming programmes. Its Career Acceleration Programme and Step-Up, the focused leadership transition support programme, are aimed at identifying leaders early and making them future-ready. Managers undertake cross-functional training. For instance, a finance professional may be exposed to operations, marketing and HR. Only those in the 30-35 age group are allowed to join the leadership programmes. The executives have mentors to help them gain exposure in a variety of roles. ■